Adult Child/Dead Child

By Claire Dowie

SPEAKER: **(Pgs 3-31)** *(with growing agitation)* Clean house, spotless, nothing out of place except me. Can't seem to please them, can't win for losing. My mother despaired of me. My sister was an angel -- never put a foot wrong; a perfect child, a joy to behold. My father was an actor: pretended to be a father, pretended to have feelings, demanded perfection. 100% do it right, do it the best. Be brainy, be sporty; be talented, be good; well-mannered, polite. Know it all, do it all. 100%. *(beat)* I failed always failed.

INTRODUCTION

Mental illness often begins invisibly, shaped by neglect, fear, and silence. In this selection, the name for that mental illness is "Benji," an imaginary friend who becomes both refuge and threat, carrying the anger a child cannot express. As violence erupts, the consequences are devastating -- but not final.

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SPEAKER: I remember being in the garden. I was about six or seven and there were friends of my parents visiting. I can't remember now who, but somebody gave me a cowboy and Indian set -- a cowboy hat and gun and holster and a tin star with the word 'sheriff' on it and an Indian feather thing with a band on it and a tomahawk. And my dad said let's play with it and first he was the cowboy and I was the Indian and everybody was watching and I ran at him with my tomahawk but he shot me so I lost. And then we changed round and I was the cowboy and my dad was the Indian but before I could shoot him, he threw the tomahawk and it hit my head and everybody laughed. *(beat)* I didn't want to play with my cowboy and Indian set anymore.

I was a clumsy child, clumsy! Never a day would go by that I wasn't walking into things, tripping up, knocking things over. It drove my parents crazy. Fidgeting was another habit I couldn't seem to shake, which annoyed my parents intensely. Once my dad got so mad about it he tied me down to a chair. My parents were great believers in eye for

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eye and tooth for tooth punishments.

(realizes how it sounds and is quick to clarify) I was never what you'd call an abused child. Not abused. But there was the cupboard under the stairs: dark, silent, claustrophobic nothing to do, nothing to say, nothing to be but lifeless, invisible. Sitting in the cupboard till I 'learn to behave myself and show some respect.' Everything I got I deserved except the cupboard under the stairs. I never locked anyone in a cupboard but my parents did. *(struggles to explain the feelings)*

When you are a child the adults have the power and they know everything -- to know what you are feeling, so you want to hit out because of this lack of love that you can't explain. They won't help you with your feelings -- this hurt and frustration because you can't explain so you stop trusting the adults. *(beat)*

My invisible friend came I think when I was 4 or 5 but by the age of 7 she was with me always -- chattering a way, making jokes telling stories. I didn't give my invisible friend a name till I was 8. . . I called her Benji. She sat next to me at the dinner table (and she didn't like cabbage either). By the time I was eight, [my parents] were telling me I was too old for imaginary friends. Stupid. Benji was still there, I could hear her, I could feel her. We did things together.

So what if my sister lost her charm bracelet! It was a horrible charm bracelet -- it rattled! *(to Mom)* I don't know maybe she just dropped it somewhere maybe it just fell off. I don't know! *(to audience)* We got away with it for a long time, mostly because Benji was a good liar and would tell me what to say if anyone asked: Benji did it. *(as Mom)* Oh, don't be so stupid. *(to Mom)* She did. It was Benji. *(as Mom)* Look, it was you, now just stop it, you're too old for all that rubbish.

(to audience) Then she's going on and on about money missing from her purse. My dad joins in; my sister sits there all innocent and perfect. It's getting on my nerves all their questions, accusations, fingers pointing in my face. *(to Mom)* Benji did it. *(to audience)* Benji's getting annoyed. Benji's getting angry, I can feel her.

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You build a wall of anger and mistrust and hatred. Further and further away, no understanding, no communication. Me and Benji in our own little world and all the rest in theirs. The only time our worlds collided was when Benji did something wrong and I got the blame for it.

Benji would swear. But it wasn't, wasn't just swearing, she had tantrums and threw things all over the room -- threw furniture! She thought it was funny. I didn't. I never wanted to get into trouble, [but] it was just trouble all the time. I couldn't control her. I couldn't stop her. She scared me. *(beat)*

Mr Kent, he was a woodwork teacher. By now I was 13 and hated by everybody including Mr Kent. Benji was in control of everything now, and I hated ***her***. *(beat)* I was making a toast rack in woodwork. Mr Kent said it was crap -- said I was a worthless human being. [He] went on and on and on till Benji jumped out and threw a hammer at him. I was suspended from school for two weeks because Mr Kent couldn't take a joke, well all right, it wasn't funny, no, it was very dangerous, but it had missed and he had asked for it.

All night I am awake, or sort of awake, or something, I'm not sure. I don't know what's happening with me. Benji doesn't stop talking, telling me that my dad's going to kill me when he finds out. Benji keeps telling me over and over . . . *(whispers in Benji's voice)* remember when you kicked your sister how he kicked you? Remember when you threw stones at those boys how he threw stones at you? An eye for an eye, tooth for tooth! *(to audience, distraught)* and I never did those things, I never did! Benji did them, it was Benji! *(beat, near tears)* I don't know what's happening. I don't! *(whispers in Benji's voice)* And the cupboard after, the cupboard, cupboard . . . he's going to kill you. *(argues with the voice)* I didn't do anything, it was you, you threw it! *(in Benji's voice, more assertive)* But they won't believe you will they, they never do, they never did *(as speaker, whimpering)* You threw the hammer . . .

(in Benji's voice, loud and strong) He's going to kill you when he finds out, he's going to kill

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you! Eye for eye, and tooth for tooth! He's going to kill you unless you kill him first. Do it first, to save yourself, to defend yourself. *(long silence)*

(to audience) It was a long night, and I can't understand any more. I don't know what's happening to me and Benji won't shut up. I don't know! *(stands quietly with a hammer drawn back)* And then it's dawn and I'm in their bedroom with the hammer and I don't understand. . . . *(brings the hammer down, shocked)*

And then I hit him with it. I hit him! Somebody had to make a move, stop the tension, do something! So I did. I did something: *(almost chanting as he hits himself in the head with the hammer)* Clear the air. Make amends. Even the score. Eye for eye. Tooth for tooth. *(stops, long beat, then in amazement)* I hit myself with the hammer. I was 13.

They sent me to a psychiatrist. *(in Benji's voice)* Lunatic. Mad. Insane.*(to audience)* I didn't know anything about psychiatrists or mental health except what I'd watched on television. *(in Benji's voice)* Deranged. Psychopath. Crazy. First you tried to hammer the woodwork teacher, then you hammered your father, then you hammered yourself.

(beat, to audience) Mental hospitals aren't that bad quite nice really. I was there for 6 weeks and they gave me some drugs to calm me down and Benji faded a bit and I got a grip of myself and felt a lot better. *(beat)* We all went to family therapy, and my parents and my sister talked and I said nothing. When the therapist asked me anything, I said I dunno. And the weeks passed and I didn't get into trouble anymore and I never went into the cupboard again and the eye for eye retributions stopped.

It made me think a lot. I had always been a disappointment to my parents, a waste of effort, now I was a waste of space. , . When I was 17 I thought the best thing to do was get out, get away, leave home.

(thoughtful) Frustration comes because you are an adult. You are no longer a child but you feel like a child because you need love like a child. You are an adult, but the child needs love . . . and the anger grows. You can't ask for love like a child because you are

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adult. *(shakes if off and continues the story)*

I was ready and they got me a flat and all my friends came and helped me decorate and arrange the furniture. I felt good, much too old for imaginary friends. But I was lonely. I couldn't bear the emptiness and silence. I'd never been on my own before -- always had Benji. Then I thought, I'm just being silly. I'm sure everybody feels like this when they move into a new place. I've just got to get used to it, just got to keep busy, not think about it. I was too old for imaginary friends but I couldn't cope on my own. And it was just at that point, just at that point when I thought "I can't do it -- have to go back to hospital or something" -- it was just at that point that I had this brilliant idea: *(suspenseful beat, then happily)* I got a dog! And she's a real dog, she's not imaginary. And we do everything together, always together, just like Benji. *(beat, a confession)*

I do sometimes have this urge though, to stop taking the medication, just for a while. I'd like Benji to come back just one more time. I feel I need to say sorry, cus I know now that it wasn't Benji really. I know that it was me really, my anger, my emotion that caused all that trouble. [Benji] was my best friend, she was, she was my best friend and I blamed her all those years, so I would just like to say sorry. And I'd like to say goodbye. *(shakes it off)*

But I can't even think about it. *(with conviction)* I'm too old for imaginary friends. I should just think about my dog, cus she makes me happy, she does! She's a great dog, a real scallywag, always into everything. I call her . . . Lady *(shrugs)* It's just a name.

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AWARD HISTORY

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